Chennai: History of the City

Introduction to Chennai

Chennai, formerly called Madras, is the capital of the Indian state of Tamil Nadu and one of the four major metropolitan cities of India. It is located on the Coromandel Coast of the Bay of Bengal and has about 4.6 million people in the city proper (2011 census) and more than 10 million in the wider metropolitan region. Chennai is known as the "Gateway to South India" and as a centre of culture, education, healthcare, information technology and manufacturing, and it has the longest urban beach in India, the Marina, about 13 kilometres long. The city has a history that goes back about two thousand years and a modern identity that began with the arrival of the British East India Company in the 17th century.

Ancient and Medieval Background

The region around Chennai was part of the ancient Tamil kingdoms. The port of Mylapore was known to ancient Greek and Roman traders, and according to Christian tradition, St. Thomas the Apostle came to Mylapore and was buried there; the San Thome Basilica stands at the site. Mylapore is also home to the ancient Kapaleeshwarar Temple and was associated with the poet-saint Thiruvalluvar. The area was ruled at different times by the Pallavas, with the capital at nearby Kanchipuram, the Cholas, the Pandyas and then the Vijayanagara Empire. The Portuguese arrived in the 16th century and built a settlement at San Thome in 1522, and the Dutch settled at Pulicat to the north. The area was then ruled by the Nayaks of Vandavasi on behalf of the Vijayanagara rulers.

How the City Began: The Founding of Madras

In 1639, the English East India Company, looking for a base on the east coast for the cotton textile trade, sent Francis Day and Andrew Cogan, who obtained a strip of land from a local Nayak ruler, Damarla Venkatapathy Nayak, the Nayak of Vandavasi, a representative of the Vijayanagara Empire. On 22 August 1639 the grant was signed, giving the English a small piece of sandy land on the coast, about three miles long, where they could build a fort and a warehouse. The place was known as Madraspatnam, and the nearby village was named Chennapatnam, after Damarla Chennappa Nayak, Venkatapathy's father. The two later merged into the single city of Madras.

When Was Fort St. George Built?

Fort St. George was built by the British East India Company between 1639 and 1644. Construction began in 1640, around St. George's Day on 23 April, and it was completed in 1644, which explains its name. It was the first English fortress in India and was the nucleus around which Madras grew. The fort was designed as a trading post and defence, and it housed warehouses, a church and homes for the company's staff. St. Mary's Church inside the fort, consecrated in 1680, is the oldest Anglican church in India and the oldest surviving British building in the country. The fort was captured by the French under La Bourdonnais in 1746 and returned to the British in 1749 under the Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle. Robert Clive and Arthur Wellesley (later the Duke of Wellington) lived in the fort at times. Today Fort St. George houses the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly and the Secretariat, and the Fort Museum.

Growth of Madras Under the British

Madras became the seat of the Madras Presidency, one of the three presidencies of British India with Bombay and Calcutta, covering most of South India. In 1688 the Madras Corporation was created, the oldest municipal body in India and among the oldest in the world outside the United Kingdom. The city developed the Madras Port, with an artificial harbour built in 1881 to 1896, the Chennai Central railway station opened in 1873, and the University of Madras in 1857, one of the first three modern universities in India. The Madras Medical College, which began in 1835, is one of the oldest medical colleges in Asia, and the Madras Christian College and Presidency College, along with the Madras High Court, built in the Indo-Saracenic style in 1892, are historic institutions. The newspaper The Hindu was started in Madras in 1878. During World War I, in September 1914, the German cruiser Emden shelled the city's oil tanks. After independence in 1947, Madras remained the capital of the Madras State, and after the reorganisation of states in 1956 it became the capital of the Tamil-speaking state, which was renamed Tamil Nadu in 1969.

When Was Madras Renamed Chennai?

Madras was renamed Chennai officially in 1996. The Tamil Nadu government, led by Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi, announced the change in August 1996 and made it effective from 17 July 1996, the same year it was decided to restore Tamil names in other cities, such as Bombay to Mumbai in 1995 and Calcutta to Kolkata in 2001. The name Chennai comes from Chennapatnam, the settlement named after Damarla Chennappa Nayak. The change was meant to reflect the city's Tamil identity and to replace a name that came from the colonial era.

Why Is 22 August Celebrated as Madras Day?

Madras Day is celebrated every year on 22 August to mark the founding of the city, because on that day in 1639 the East India Company obtained the land grant from the local Nayak ruler on which Fort St. George and the city of Madras grew. The first Madras Day was celebrated in 2004, thanks to the initiative of the journalist and historian S. Muthiah, with Vincent D'Souza and Sashi Nair. Since then, the celebration has grown into a week-long festival, now called Madras Week, with heritage walks, talks, exhibitions, quizzes, food festivals and music events about the city's history. Because the city is older than the grant, some historians say that Chennai is much older, but 22 August 1639 is taken as the official founding date. In 2024 the city celebrated its 385th birthday and in 2025 its 386th.

Modern Chennai

Chennai grew into an important industrial and educational centre after independence. IIT Madras was established in 1959 with German help. The Integral Coach Factory at Perambur began in 1955, and the automobile and electronics industries, the software parks along the Old Mahabalipuram Road, the Chennai Metro, which began in 2015, and the Chennai Port and Ennore Port have made the city a major economic hub. It is a centre of Tamil cinema (Kollywood), Carnatic music and classical dance, with the famous December Music Season. The city has faced challenges such as the floods of December 2015, when heavy northeast monsoon rain caused enormous destruction, the Cyclone Vardah of December 2016, the water crisis of 2019 and Cyclone Michaung in December 2023.

Heritage Landmarks

Important landmarks include Fort St. George, the Madras High Court building, Ripon Building, Chennai Central, Victoria Public Hall, the Government Museum in Egmore, Valluvar Kottam, the Kapaleeshwarar Temple, Santhome Church, Marina Beach, the Chepauk stadium and the Connemara Public Library.

Quick Facts

- Fort St. George was built by the East India Company between 1639 and 1644; construction began in 1640.
- Madras was officially renamed Chennai in 1996 (effective 17 July 1996).
- Madras Day is celebrated on 22 August because the land grant for the city was made on 22 August 1639.
- The Madras Corporation, created in 1688, is the oldest municipal body in India.
- The name Chennai comes from Chennapatnam, named after Damarla Chennappa Nayak.